"IN THE BEGINNING..."

GENESIS 37

IN 5 MINUTES

When:

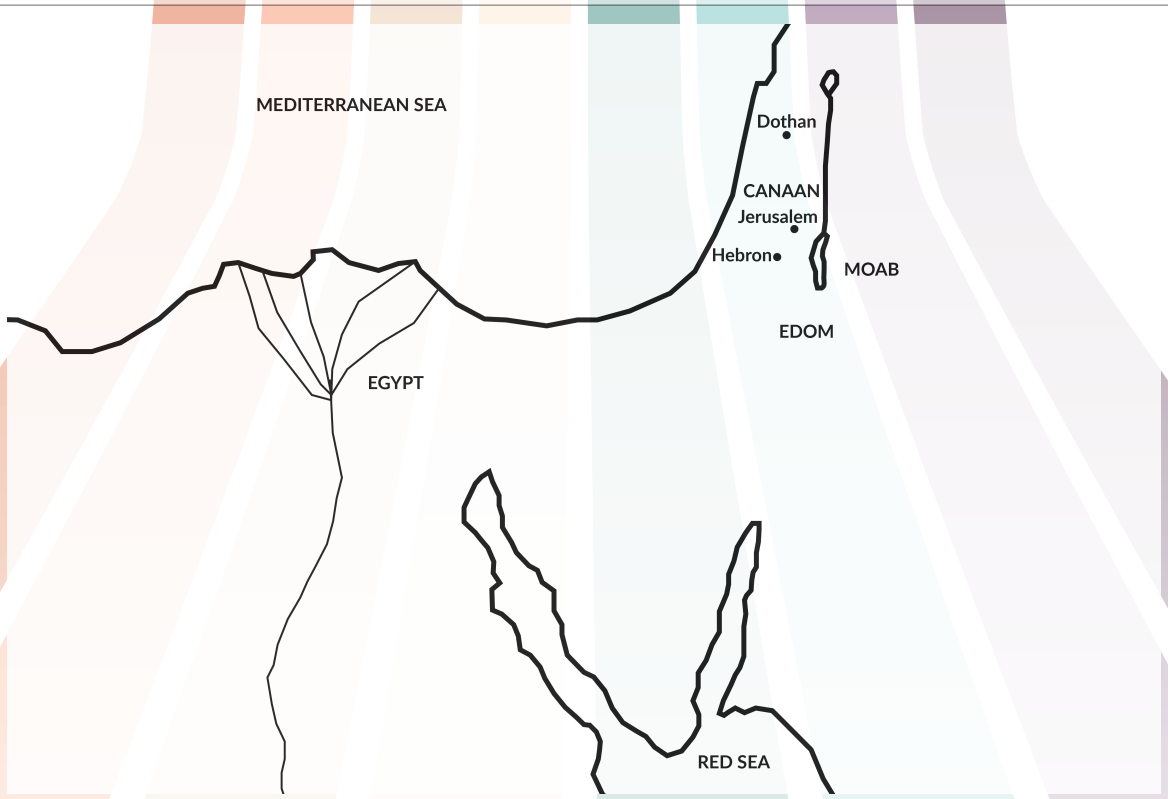
- Joseph was 17 when his brothers sold him into slavery in Egypt (approx. 1728 B.C.).
- Although Isaac's death was recorded in Genesis 35, he was still alive when Joseph went to Egypt. He died in approximately 1716 B.C.).

Characters:

- Jacob – The son of Isaac. The Lord changed his name to Israel.
- Joseph – Jacob's son with Rachel. He was Jacob's favorite son "because he was the son of his old age" (37:3).
- Joseph's brothers – Jacob had 11 sons besides Joseph. Their names were: Reuben, Simeon, Levi, Judah, Issachar, Zebulun, Dan, Naphtali, Gad, Asher, and Benjamin.

Where:

- According to verse 14, Jacob's camp was in Hebron (Valley of Hebron).
- Joseph's brothers were in Dothan pasturing their flock.
- Joseph was sold into slavery in Egypt.



Outline:

- INTRODUCTION TO JOSEPH (37:1-4):
    + The chapter opens by reintroducing us to Joseph, Jacob's favorite son, when he was 17 years old.
    + Joseph's brothers hated him because he was their father's favorite.
    + Jacob gave Joseph a robe of many colors.
- JOSEPH'S DREAMS (37:5-11):
    + One day, Joseph had a dream which he recounted to his brothers.
    + He dreamed they were binding sheaves in the field and his stood upright while his brother's sheaves bowed down to his.
    + His brothers hated him even more after he told them the dream.
    + Joseph dreamed a second dream and told it to his brothers.
    + In the second dream, the sun, moon, and 11 stars bowed down to him.
    + Jacob rebuked Joseph saying, "Shall I and your mother and your brothers indeed come to bow ourselves to the ground before you?"
- JOSEPH'S BROTHERS SELL HIM INTO SLAVERY (37:12-36):
    + Jacob sent Joseph to check on his brothers who were pasturing his flock.
    + Joseph found them in Dothan.
    + As he approached, his brothers plotted to kill him, but Reuben convinced them not to harm him but to throw him into a pit (Reuben planned to return and save him).
    + The brothers seized Joseph, took his coat and threw him into a pit.
    + A while later, while Reuben was away, Joseph's brothers sold him to a passing caravan of Ishmaelites headed to Egypt.
    + They sold Joseph for 20 shekels of silver.
    + In order to deceive their father about Joseph's true fate, the brothers killed a goat and dipped the robe of many colors into its blood.
    + They brought the robe to their father and allowed him to believe Joseph had been attacked by a wild animal.
    + Jacob put on sackcloth and mourned many days for his son.
    + Jacob's son and daughters tried to comfort him, but he couldn't be consoled.
    + Joseph was sold as a slave to Potiphar, "an officer of Pharaoh."

Application:

- Life may not always be fair, but envy is not the right response.
- It wasn't fair that Joseph was the favored child, but his 11 brothers couldn't control their father's favoritism, they could only control their response to the reality of it.
- We can't control the fact that life isn't fair, we can only control the way we respond to the realities of the world.
- Envy doesn't solve anything, and it is listed as one of the "works of the flesh" (Gal 5)
- Although we may not understand why things are the way they are, we can be confident God is in control of His world, and all things will be made right in the end. God will see to it.
- With that knowledge, we can be at peace in an unfair world.